

Gender and Society (HS8. 306)

Mid-Term Exam, Monsoon 2026

Max Marks: 20

Time: Up to 1.5 hours

Please answer all questions in up to 400 words. Each question is worth 4 points.

Please take time to plan your answers. Do not use bullet points. Write in full sentences and paragraphs.

Do not plagiarise. This test is for you to demonstrate your understanding of the class material. Please know that you shall be penalised for not following instructions.

1. What is *Mundium*? What is the link between *mundium* and family law? Explain in relation to Simone de Beauvoir's discussion women and patriarchy.
2. What is a totem? Use the concept to explain the relationship between nature and women in early agricultural societies.
3. Write a note describing a historical materialist understanding of the centrality of inheritance in the unequal distribution of power between genders. How does this centrality shape the value and role of women in society? Use the example of any one societal system to demonstrate your point.
4. Simone de Beauvoir suggests that literature and popular imagination of the Middle Ages reflect Christian theology's derogatory and oppressive view of women. Elucidate one instance that provides a prototype for a secondary conception of women in the literature she discusses. In addition, think of one instance in popular culture prevalent today where her thesis still holds.
5. How does Simone de Beauvoir critique Engels' theory of Private Property and the family? In what ways does historical materialism fail to explain fully private property and oppressive gender relations? What does she propose as possible counter-explanations?

